

Thus, it was only natural that I should choose Los Angeles as the place to enjoy the money I'd made in the oil fields.

"I've made my fortune—and I'm going to retire," I announced blandly to my startled parents.

Neither Mother nor Father was pleased with my decision. Both of them had worked very hard in their own youth. When first married, my mother had continued to work as a schoolteacher to help provide my father with the money he needed to put him through law school. Both of them firmly believed that an individual had to work to justify his existence, and that a rich person had to keep his money working to justify its existence. My father tried to impress upon me that a businessman's money is capital to be invested and reinvested.

"You've got to use your money to create, operate and build businesses," he argued. "Your wealth represents potential jobs for countless others—and it can produce wealth and a better life for a great many people as well as for yourself."

I'm afraid I didn't pay much attention to him—then.

Later, I was to realize the truth of what he said, but first I had to try things my own way. I owned a spanking new Cadillac roadster, good clothes and had all the money I could possibly need. I had made up my mind I wanted to play, and with these prerequisites, I encountered no difficulty plunging full tilt into the Southern California-Los Angeles-Hollywood whirl of fun and frolic. Although the United States entered the war, my call-up was first delayed, then postponed by bureaucratic snarls, and finally

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I was informed that my "services would not be needed." I consequently spent the World War One years playing and enjoying myself.

It took me a while to wake up to the fact that I was only wasting time and that I was bored. By the end of 1918, I was thoroughly fed up. Early in 1919, I was back in the oil business—not a little abashed by the "I told you